

THE

Extra Year

PLAYBOOK

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A few disclaimers

- By Jack Hartley

- FamilyForce

- A note on medical advice: This book is based on published clinical studies, academic journals, pediatric guidelines, books, the author's experience, and a variety of other sources. It is not a substitute for guidance from your child's pediatrician or a qualified education specialist. Every child is different. If something in this book does not match what you are seeing, trust your doctor and your child's school team over this guidebook.

- A note on pronouns: I refer to the child as "he" throughout because I have two sons. Everything in this book applies equally to daughters unless stated otherwise.

- A note on scope: This book covers Kindergarten through Grade 4. If your child is in fifth grade or older, the research shifts significantly and so does the advice. That is a different book. This one is for the early years, where the decisions carry the most weight and the window for getting it right is still wide open.

Before We Start: A Note for the Parent Reading This

If you are reading this because someone just called you in for a meeting, or because you have been lying awake wondering whether something is wrong, give yourself a minute before you read anything else.

This is a hard thing to be in the middle of. Not because the decision is necessarily catastrophic. But because when it involves your child and his school and his future, even a manageable situation feels enormous. That is a normal response.

Most parents who go through this do not tell anyone. They sit in the meeting and nod and say they will think about it. They drive home quietly. They do not call their friends because they are not sure how to explain it. The silence around this topic makes it lonelier than it needs to be.

You are not the first parent who did not know what to ask in that room. You are not the only one who went home and felt something between fear and guilt and not knowing what comes next.

And this: nothing about your child being flagged for an extra year is a verdict on you as a parent. Children develop at different rates. Schools have limited time and large classrooms. Some things get missed. None of that is a moral failure.

This book is what I wish I had before I walked into that first meeting. It will not make the decision simple. But it will make sure you are asking the right questions, you understand what the research actually says, and you are not going along with the first option anyone puts on the table.

That is what being prepared looks like. And it is enough.

Chapter 1: The Most Important Meeting You Were Not Prepared For

FIRST SON & SECOND SON

First Son was born in July.

I mention that because it matters more than I understood at the time. He started kindergarten just after turning five, one of the youngest kids in his class. A September birthday kid sitting next to him had been alive ten months longer. At age five, ten months is not a small gap.

The school noticed it by spring. They called us in and explained that First Son was struggling. Not academically, exactly. He knew his letters. He could count. But socially and emotionally he was behind. He had meltdowns over things his classmates handled without incident. He struggled to hold it together at the end of a long day in ways his teacher said were meaningfully different from his peers.

They recommended he stay back and repeat kindergarten. They used words like "gift of time" and "a chance to grow into himself." They were kind about it. They clearly believed what they were saying.

I nodded. My wife asked a few questions. We agreed.

I did not ask what would be different about the repeated year. I did not ask whether a July birthday might explain most of what they were describing, or whether a specific evaluation might reveal something more. I just agreed.

First Son repeated kindergarten. Same school, same approach. He was more settled the second year. Looking back, I am not sure how much of that was the extra year and how much was simply that he was now a year older than most of his classmates instead of a year younger.

He found his footing. But I have noticed something over the years I did not expect. He approaches hard things carefully, almost cautiously. His first instinct when something is difficult is to pull back rather than push through. I cannot prove that has anything to do with kindergarten. But I have wondered. I would have liked to know that before the meeting.

With Second Son, things went differently. I knew about the summer birthday research. I knew that boys born between June and August are the most likely to be flagged for immaturity in kindergarten, the most likely to be recommended for an extra year, and that much of what gets called unreadiness is simply being young for a grade. I knew that delaying kindergarten entry by one year produces better outcomes than entering on time and repeating later.

So when Second Son turned five in August, I made a different call. He started kindergarten at six. He was one of the oldest in his class instead of the youngest. The experience was calmer. The school never raised the concerns they had raised with First Son.

The difference was not that Second Son was a different kid. The difference was that I had read the research before the meeting instead of after it.

THE SCIENCE

Here is the finding that stopped me cold when I first read it.

In 2005, researchers asked elementary and middle school students to rate the most stressful things they could imagine happening to them. The list included losing a parent. Going blind. Getting caught stealing.

The students rated being held back a grade as the single most stressful experience on the list.

More stressful than losing a parent.

That result has been replicated. It is not an outlier. And it is the reason the decision you are facing deserves more than a nod in a school meeting.

The research on holding children back spans more than fifty years and hundreds of studies. The honest summary is this:

The extra year gives a short term academic boost. That boost usually fades within two to three years. Whether it produces lasting benefit depends almost entirely on what happens differently during that year.

That fading is the finding that shapes the mainstream consensus against holding kids back. The American Academy of Pediatrics, the National Association of School Psychologists, and most education researchers who published before 2010 share that position. They are not wrong. Short term gains that disappear are not an argument for putting a child through the most stressful experience they can imagine.

But the research did not stop there.

In 2017, a team of Harvard economists studied Florida's third grade reading policy. Florida required third graders who scored at the lowest level on the state reading test to repeat the year. The researchers compared children who scored just barely above the cutoff to children who scored just barely below it — nearly identical in every measurable way except one group advanced and one group stayed back.

The children who stayed back showed large gains in reading and math. Those gains persisted through high school. They took fewer remedial courses. They earned higher GPAs. They graduated at the same rate as the children who advanced.

A 2023 study from Indiana found the same pattern. Students who repeated third grade scored more than 18 percentile points higher in reading and math by fourth grade. Those gains held for five years.

The difference is what Florida and Indiana required alongside the extra year: intensive reading intervention, different instruction, progress monitoring, a real plan. The children in those programs did not simply repeat the year. They repeated it differently.

That is the mechanism. The extra year is not the intervention. A genuinely different year is.

When researchers have studied holding children back without changed instruction — same teacher, same curriculum — the results are poor. The gains are smaller, they fade faster, and the emotional cost remains.

Children who are held back are significantly more likely to drop out of school later. That association is real and correlational. The more rigorous studies, including Florida and Indiana, show no graduation penalty when a real support plan accompanies the decision. The dropout risk is highest when children are held back more than once with no change in approach.

The grade also matters. Holding a child back in Kindergarten or first grade produces better outcomes than doing it in third or fourth grade, which produces better outcomes than doing it in middle school. This book covers Kindergarten through Grade 4. After that, the research tips significantly negative.

THE LESSON

The extra year is not good or bad. It is only worth the emotional cost if something about the year is genuinely different.

The question is never "should my child repeat this grade."

The question is "what specifically will be different about the instruction, and is that plan worth what it costs my child to stay back while his friends move on."

If the school can answer that clearly and specifically, the conversation is worth having. If they cannot, you have your answer.

TRY THIS

1. Sit with the stress finding before you do anything else. Your child will experience this as the most significant thing that has happened to him. That does not mean the decision is wrong. It means the conversation with him deserves the same level of preparation as the conversation with the school.
2. Write down exactly what the school told you. What specific skills or standards did they say your child is missing? Vague language like "not at grade level" is the first thing to push back on. Vague reasoning produces vague plans.
3. Ask one question before the next meeting: "What will be different?" Not "what will happen." What will actually be different about the instruction next year compared to this year. Write down their answer.
4. Do not make the decision in the meeting. You are allowed to say "we need a few days to think about this." Any school that pressures you to decide on the spot is not a school that has a real plan ready.
5. Do not tell your child anything yet. One conversation, when you have real information, is better than two conversations and a correction.

Chapter 2: Is This Your Child or the School?

FIRST SON & SECOND SON

When the school told me First Son was emotionally and socially behind his classmates, my first instinct was to look at him. What was he doing wrong. What were we doing wrong at home. How had we missed it.

That is a natural instinct. It is also sometimes the wrong one.

First Son was a July baby, five years and two months old on his first day of kindergarten, the youngest or close to the youngest in his class. Looking back, most of what the school described as immaturity was consistent with simply being younger than his peers. He was not behind children his age. He was behind children who were up to a year older than him.

I did not know to look for that distinction. I assumed the school had already factored it in. They had not raised it. I had not asked.

With Second Son, I knew that summer birthday boys are the most commonly flagged group for social and emotional immaturity in early elementary school, and that this gap closes on its own by third or fourth grade for most children. When concerns came up with Second Son, the first question I asked was where does the problem actually live — his development, or his age relative to his classmates.

THE SCIENCE

The single most useful diagnostic question a parent can ask is this: does the problem appear everywhere, or mainly at school.

Developmental unreadiness is global. It shows up at birthday parties, at the dinner table, on the soccer field. A child who is genuinely not ready for the next grade is not just struggling in reading class. He is struggling with the general demands of being the age he is.

School-based failure is specific. The child can hold a conversation, build complicated things, navigate a playground with older kids. But homework is a disaster and test scores are low. That gap between functional intelligence and academic performance often points to instruction, environment, or an unidentified learning difference. It rarely points to developmental unreadiness.

Academic signs at home that matter:

For kindergarten and first grade, watch for a child who cannot identify most letters by January, does not understand that words are made of sounds, cannot sound out a simple word by spring. For second and third grade, watch for a child who still reads aloud slowly with frequent errors, cannot tell you the main idea of a short paragraph, or avoids reading whenever possible.

Social and emotional signs that matter:

Academic readiness and social readiness are different things, and schools frequently flag one when the real issue is the other.

A child who is not socially ready for the next grade is not just shy. He cannot share and take turns without significant adult intervention. He has meltdowns over routine changes that his classmates handle without incident. He struggles to read basic social cues in group settings. He seems, consistently, like the youngest person in any room of same-age kids.

These behaviors matter at home and at school. If they appear only at school, the school environment may be the problem. If they appear everywhere, you have a different conversation to have.

Physical readiness: the part nobody talks about:

Boys develop physically later than girls, and that gap is most pronounced in the early elementary years. A boy who has noticeably less developed fine motor control in handwriting, cutting, and drawing, or who struggles with the physical stamina a full school day requires, may be dealing with a developmental gap that has nothing to do with intelligence.

Fine motor skills matter more in early school than parents realize. Writing, drawing, coloring, using scissors — these are assessed directly. A child whose hands are not yet ready for those tasks will appear behind in ways that have nothing to do with reading comprehension.

Gross motor development matters too. A child who cannot sit still, falls out of chairs, or seems physically uncoordinated compared to peers may be dealing with developmental gaps in balance and body awareness. These are real, common in young boys, and frequently misread as behavioral or attention issues.

If physical development concerns you, your pediatrician is the right first call.

An important caution on emotional immaturity:

The summer birthday explanation is often correct. But it is not the only explanation.

Social and emotional immaturity that is significant, persistent, and shows up across multiple settings can also be an early presentation of a mild autism spectrum difference, an anxiety disorder, or a sensory processing difficulty. These conditions can look, in a kindergarten classroom, almost identical to being young for the grade.

If the social and emotional concerns are substantial, ask specifically for a developmental pediatrician or child psychologist to be involved in the evaluation before any grade placement decision is made. A summer birthday explains many things. It does not explain everything.

The summer birthday factor:

Research consistently shows that the youngest children in any grade — those born in June, July, and August in most school calendar systems — are significantly more likely to be identified as struggling, more likely to be recommended for holding back, and more likely to receive ADHD diagnoses. Most of them are not developmentally delayed. They are simply young for their grade.

Before any conversation about holding a child back, ask: when is his birthday, and where does that put him relative to his classmates.

THE LESSON

The problem has a location. Find it before you try to fix it.

If the struggle appears everywhere, the conversation about an extra year is worth having. If it appears mainly at school, the conversation about what the school is doing differently is the one to have first.

TRY THIS

1. Watch your child outside of school for one week before your next meeting. Dinner. Sports. Playdates. Note specifically what he can and cannot do in those settings. Bring those observations to the meeting. They are data.
2. Ask the school which concerns are academic and which are social or behavioral. These are different problems with different solutions. A school that bundles everything into one recommendation may not have separated the diagnosis from the prescription.
3. Consider his birthday. If he is a summer birthday, especially a boy born between May and August, he may be the youngest in the class by a significant margin. Ask the school whether they have factored that in. Most do not unless you ask.

4. Check his physical development against what the grade actually demands. Ask his teacher specifically what fine motor tasks are expected. Ask whether he is meeting them. If struggling, ask whether the school has assessed for developmental gaps versus academic gaps.
5. Ask his pediatrician and come prepared. Bring the school's written concerns to the appointment. Ask three things: does this look like normal developmental variation for his age, are there signs that warrant a developmental screening, and who should we see for a psychoeducational evaluation if we need one.

Chapter 3: The Other Options

FIRST SON & SECOND SON

When the school recommended that First Son repeat kindergarten, there was one option on the table.

That is not unusual. Schools are large institutions with standard processes. The path they know best is the path they offer. I did not know enough to ask whether there were other paths.

I found out later that there were. Targeted tutoring at the right intensity produces gains larger than the extra year alone. Summer retesting might have changed the timeline entirely. An evaluation for a learning disability would have either changed the recommendation or strengthened it by ruling everything else out.

With Second Son, I knew the list before I sat down. The extra year was one option among several. I walked in understanding that agreeing to it without knowing the alternatives was the same mistake I had made the first time.

Whatever the school puts on the table, your job is to know what is not on it.

THE SCIENCE

The central finding of all the extra year research is that the interventions produce the gains, not the year itself. If you can get the interventions without the year, the outcome may be the same without the cost.

High dosage tutoring:

A 2020 review by Nickow, Oreopoulos, and Quan for the National Bureau of Economic Research analyzed ninety-six randomized and quasi-experimental studies. The conclusion was unambiguous. High dosage tutoring, meaning three or more sessions per week with a trained tutor working individually or in very small groups, produces large and consistent academic gains that regularly exceed what is seen in grade repetition studies.

Not all tutoring is equal. A weekly session with a generalist who reviews homework is not this. A trained reading specialist working with a child three times a week using a structured literacy program is. Ask about frequency, specificity, and what program the tutor uses.

The summer retesting window:

Many school districts allow children to be retested at the end of summer. If a child demonstrates proficiency on that assessment, the grade placement recommendation may change. Six to eight weeks of targeted summer tutoring has repeatedly moved children from below the threshold to above it. This option is often not mentioned unless parents ask for it specifically.

Ask for it. Use these words: if my child demonstrates proficiency on a retesting assessment at the end of summer, would the grade placement recommendation change. Get the answer in writing before summer starts.

IEP and 504 plans:

For a child with an identified learning disability, an IEP provides access to specially designed instruction delivered by credentialed specialists. Research consistently shows that students with learning disabilities who receive this instruction outperform similar students who are held back without additional support.

A 504 plan provides accommodations within the regular classroom: extra time on tests, preferential seating, access to audiobooks. For a child whose needs can be met within the regular curriculum with accommodations, a 504 plan may be sufficient to prevent the academic spiral that leads to a grade placement recommendation.

Reading Recovery:

For first graders specifically, Reading Recovery is a one on one program delivered by a trained teacher for approximately twenty weeks, designed to bring struggling readers to grade level. The What Works Clearinghouse rates it as having strong evidence of effectiveness. If the school is recommending holding a first grader back but has not tried Reading Recovery first, ask why not.

Extended year and extended day programs:

Well designed summer school programs, specifically those using structured instruction rather than enrichment activities, can produce gains equivalent to two to three months of additional school year learning. Extended day programs produce similar results when the instruction is targeted and intentional. Ask what specific program is used and what outcomes are tracked.

The social and physical alternatives:

If the school's concern is primarily social, emotional, or physical, the alternatives look different. A child who is socially immature may benefit from targeted social skills groups or occupational therapy for sensory or motor development issues more than from an extra year of the same academic content. A child with fine motor delays affecting writing may need occupational therapy, not a different grade.

Ask the school what specific intervention addresses the specific concern. If the concern is social and the solution is an academic grade repetition, the match between problem and solution does not hold up.

THE LESSON

The extra year is one option on a list. Know the list before you choose.

The school may not put the full list in front of you. Your job is to ask about what is not on the table. If you try alternatives first and they are not enough, the extra year remains available.

TRY THIS

1. Ask the school explicitly: what alternatives have been considered, and why were they ruled out. The answer tells you a lot about how thoroughly the recommendation was developed.
2. Look into high dosage tutoring before school ends. Specifically a reading specialist who uses structured literacy. Three sessions per week minimum. Ask about the specific program they use.
3. Ask about summer retesting today. Not at the end of summer. Now. Find out whether it exists in your district, what the assessment is, and what score would change the recommendation.
4. Request an IEP evaluation in writing if you have not already. The evaluation either finds something that changes the plan, or it clears that question and you make the grade placement decision with more confidence.
5. If the school's concern includes physical or social factors, request a specialist evaluation. Physical concerns: occupational therapy assessment. Social-emotional concerns: evaluation by a licensed school psychologist or child therapist. Grade placement decisions should be made from the full picture.

Chapter 4: One Question the School Probably Did Not Ask

FIRST SON & SECOND SON

When First Son repeated kindergarten, nobody evaluated him for anything.

The school had flagged social and emotional immaturity. They recommended an extra year. I agreed. That was the full extent of the diagnostic process.

Nobody looked underneath "not ready" to ask what not ready actually meant in his case. Nobody asked whether knowing why he was struggling might change what a genuinely different year should look like.

That is the question. Not should he stay back. Why is he struggling, and does the answer change what the plan should be.

With Second Son, I knew the sequence matters. Before agreeing to any grade placement decision, the first question is why. What is the specific cause. Does the cause have a name. Does the proposed solution actually address the cause, or does it just buy time.

THE SCIENCE

Here is a number that should change how every school approaches these conversations.

Fifty-eight percent of children with learning disabilities are held back a grade before anyone identifies the learning disability.

More than half. Held back first. Diagnosed later.

That sequence is backwards. An extra year does nothing for a child whose struggle has a specific cause that the year does not address.

Dyslexia:

Dyslexia is the most common learning disability, affecting between eight and fifteen percent of the population. It is not an intelligence issue. It is a neurological difference in how the brain processes the relationship between sounds and letters.

Children with dyslexia do not outgrow it. Giving a dyslexic child another year of the same reading instruction that is not working for him does not fix dyslexia. It gives him another year of an approach that cannot reach how his brain works.

The effective interventions are specific: structured literacy programs, systematic phonics, explicit instruction in sound symbol relationships. A child who is struggling to read and has not been screened for dyslexia has not been fully evaluated. Full stop.

ADHD:

Children with ADHD are two to three times more likely to repeat a grade than their peers. Not because they are less capable, but because traditional academic assessment directly penalizes ADHD symptoms. Sit still, work independently, complete a worksheet, take a timed test. These formats punish inattention and impulsivity regardless of what the child actually knows.

Properly treated ADHD produces significant and lasting academic gains. Holding back a child with undiagnosed ADHD gives him another year in an environment that is not designed for how his brain works.

Vision and hearing:

A child who cannot see the board clearly, or who has even mild hearing loss in one ear, will struggle academically in ways that look exactly like a learning disability. The fix is not a different grade.

Ask when your child last had a full vision exam and a hearing evaluation. Not a school screening. A full exam with an optometrist and an audiologist. If the answer is not within the last year, schedule both before you make any grade placement decision.

The evaluation you can request:

A full psychoeducational evaluation — a structured assessment conducted by a psychologist measuring how a child thinks, learns, and processes information — covers cognitive ability, processing speed, working memory, phonological awareness, and academic achievement. It tells you what is going on underneath the surface.

In the United States, under the Individuals with Disabilities Education Act, parents have the legal right to request a full evaluation from the school at no cost. The school must respond within sixty days. Most parents do not know they have this right.

The right sequence:

Evaluate first. Understand why. Then make the grade placement decision. If you know why he is struggling, you know what a genuinely different year needs to look like. If you do not, you are building a plan without knowing what is underneath it.

THE LESSON

Before you agree to an extra year, ask: do we know why he is struggling.

If the answer is no, the first step is an evaluation, not a grade placement decision. It may reveal something that changes the recommendation entirely. And if it reveals nothing, you are making the decision with a complete picture.

TRY THIS

1. Ask the school directly: has my child been evaluated for a learning disability or processing disorder. If the answer is no, request one in writing before you agree to anything. Date the letter. Keep a copy.
2. Schedule a full vision exam and hearing evaluation this week. Not a school screening. A proper exam. Do this before the next school meeting if at all possible.
3. Learn the term phonological awareness. It is the ability to hear and manipulate the individual sounds inside words — knowing that "cat" is made of three sounds, or that "bat" and "cat" rhyme because they share the same ending sound. It is the strongest early predictor of reading success and the core deficit in dyslexia.
4. If ADHD is a possibility, bring it up with your pediatrician, not the school. The school telling you your child cannot sit still is an observation. Your pediatrician assessing whether that behavior reflects ADHD is a diagnosis. Those are different things.
5. To request a formal evaluation, write to the school. Use these words: "I am writing to formally request a comprehensive psychoeducational evaluation for my child under the Individuals with Disabilities Education Act. Please respond in writing with the timeline for completing this evaluation." That letter starts a legal clock.

Chapter 5: What to Say in the Room

FIRST SON & SECOND SON

When the school recommended that First Son repeat kindergarten, the meeting lasted maybe twenty minutes.

They described what they were seeing. I listened. My wife asked a few things. We thanked them for letting us know.

Nobody asked what specifically would be different about the repeated year. We were told he needed more time and I accepted that as a complete answer.

I have thought many times about what would have happened if I had asked even one specific question. What exactly are the goals for next year. What will the teacher do differently. How will we know by December whether it is working.

Those are not hard questions. I just did not know they mattered.

With Second Son, I brought a list to the meeting. The school responded differently. Not defensively. Several answers reassured me the plan was more specific than I expected. A few showed me exactly where the plan was thin and where I needed to push.

The questions did their job.

THE SCIENCE

The research on holding children back is consistent on one point: the quality of what happens during the extra year determines whether the outcome is positive or negative. The Florida and Indiana results came down entirely to whether the year was genuinely different.

If the outcome depends on the plan, your job is to evaluate the plan before agreeing to it.

Questions about academic instruction:

What specific skills or standards did my child not master this year. Ask for a written list. Vague answers are not specific enough to build a plan around.

What will be different about the instruction next year. Not more time. What will actually change.

Will he have a different teacher. If so, why was this teacher selected for his specific needs.

What intervention program will be used. Ask for the name. Reading Recovery, Wilson, and Orton Gillingham are structured literacy programs with evidence behind them. "Extra reading support" is not a program.

How many minutes per day of targeted intervention.

What are the monthly benchmarks and what does success look like at October, January, March.

What happens if he is not meeting benchmarks by January. Is there an escalation plan.

Questions about evaluation:

Has my child been evaluated for a learning disability or processing disorder. If not, when will that begin.

Is an IEP or 504 plan being developed alongside the grade placement decision.

Have vision and hearing been evaluated recently by specialists.

Questions about social and emotional support:

What is the plan for the social transition during the first week. His current classmates will be in the class above him.

What role will the school counselor play during the repeated year.

What strategies will be used to build positive relationships with the new class.

Questions about communication:

How often will the teacher communicate progress to us.

Who is our primary point of contact for concerns during the year.

What is the process if we feel the plan is not working.

The question that tells you everything:

In specific terms, what will be different about the instruction my child receives next year compared to this year.

Not more time. Not a fresh start. What will actually change. If the school cannot answer that clearly, you have what you need to make a different decision.

THE LESSON

You are not being difficult by asking these questions. You are doing your job.

A school that has a real plan will welcome them. A school that cannot answer them has told you everything you need to know about whether the extra year will work.

TRY THIS

1. Print this chapter and bring it to the meeting. Or write the questions on an index card. Having them on paper communicates that you are prepared and that you expect specific answers.
2. Write down every answer the school gives and ask for a written summary at the end. Say: "Can you send us a written summary of what was discussed and what the plan includes." Schools with real plans put them in writing. Schools without them do not.
3. If they cannot name the specific intervention program, ask why not. A school recommending an extra year should be able to tell you exactly what different instructional approach will be used.
4. Ask about the social plan specifically. Many school teams focus entirely on academics and underinvest in the social transition. A good school will have thought about the first day back, the friend who moved up, the new peer group.

Chapter 6: What You Are Allowed to Do

FIRST SON & SECOND SON

When First Son's school recommended holding him back, I did not know I had any say in it.

I assumed the school had the authority. I was there to listen and then sign whatever they put in front of me.

I did not know that in many places, parents have meaningful legal rights in these decisions. I did not know I could slow the process down, request an evaluation, or in some states simply say no. I found out later. It did not help First Son.

With Second Son, I had read enough to know the dynamic before I walked in. I was not there to comply. I was there to participate — to ask the questions that would determine whether a genuinely different year was actually on offer. That is a different posture and it produces a different conversation.

THE SCIENCE

Regardless of where you live, two things are true. The school has real authority. And that authority is not unchecked. In every country covered here, parents are recognized as participants in the decision. In more countries than most parents realize, the school cannot hold a child back without the parent's agreement.

Universal principles — these apply everywhere:

You do not need to memorize all of this before your next meeting. Knowing that you have rights, even in general terms, changes how you sit in the room. That is enough to start.

A recommendation to hold a child back without a specific plan for what will be different is incomplete anywhere. Ask for the plan in writing. Ask what specifically will change. Ask what the benchmarks are.

Bring documentation from your child's pediatrician to any meeting where grade placement is being discussed. A letter from a doctor carries weight in every system.

United States:

The rules vary by state, and the range is wide.

In Texas, the Education Code gives parents explicit authority to override a school's recommendation. The parent's decision is final. The district must comply.

In Ohio, a 2023 law gives parents the same authority. The school cannot hold a child back against a parent's explicit written refusal.

In most other states, parents have the right to be informed, to participate, and to appeal formally. A handful of states, including Florida, have mandatory grade repetition laws tied to reading assessments, but even these include formal exemption processes that parents can pursue.

When a child has an IEP, a change in grade placement is a change in educational placement under the Individuals with Disabilities Education Act. That triggers federal safeguards: the right to participate in the meeting, written prior notice, the right to mediation, and the right to due process. Under the same law, any parent can request a full evaluation in writing. The school must respond within sixty days.

Australia:

Holding a child back requires parental consent. If parents do not agree, the principal cannot require the child to repeat. Australia's approach leans against grade repetition as a default. Research from John Hattie, whose meta-analysis of 207 studies is the most cited in the Australian context, found an average negative effect from repeating a year without targeted support. New South Wales formally discontinued the practice in primary schools in 2010.

United Kingdom:

Grade repetition is genuinely rare in the UK. When it does come up, guidance from the Department for Education states that decisions to place a child outside their chronological age group should involve informed parental consent and the agreement of everyone involved. The headteacher makes the final call, but school, parents, and relevant professionals should all be aligned before any such placement is made.

For a child with an Education, Health and Care Plan, parents can appeal any placement decision through the SEND Tribunal under the Children and Families Act 2014.

Canada:

Policies vary by province. Parental involvement in grade placement decisions is generally required, and parents in most provinces have the right to refuse a recommendation to hold a child back, particularly in the early grades. British Columbia and Alberta generally promote students through the early grades regardless of academic achievement, focusing instead on differentiated instruction and learning support.

Hong Kong:

Hong Kong's Education Bureau views holding a child back as an exceptional measure. The Bureau limits the whole-school repetition rate at publicly funded primary schools to no more than three percent of total enrollment. The principal holds formal authority, but the Bureau's guidance is explicit that schools should discuss all alternatives with parents before recommending repetition and approach the decision collaboratively.

THE LESSON

You are a participant in this decision. Not just a recipient of it.

The school has expertise and that deserves respect. But in every country covered here, parents are recognized as partners. Know your rights, not to win an argument, but to secure the conditions that make a genuinely different year possible.

TRY THIS

1. Find out the specific rules in your system before the meeting. Search for your country or state plus "parent rights grade placement" or "repeating a year parental consent." Know whether you have a veto, an appeal right, or a collaborative process.
2. If you are in the US and your child has an IEP, read it before the meeting. Find the section on educational placement and procedural safeguards. If you do not have a copy, request one in writing today.
3. If you want to refuse the recommendation, do it in writing. A verbal refusal is easily forgotten. A written refusal with a date and your signature is a document. Keep a copy.
4. Ask about summer retesting by name. Ask whether it exists in your system, what the threshold is, and get the answer in writing before summer starts.

Chapter 7: The Year Does Not Run Itself

FIRST SON & SECOND SON

When First Son repeated kindergarten, we mostly waited.

We agreed to the plan and assumed the school would execute it. By spring it was clear the progress we had hoped for had not fully materialized. We had agreed to the year. We had not taken ownership of it.

Agreeing to the extra year is not the work. The work is what you do during it. The Florida and Indiana gains did not happen because children repeated a year. They happened because the year was actively different. More intervention, more targeted instruction, more monitoring. The year ran because someone made it run.

With Second Son, when he needed additional support, I stayed in contact with his teacher monthly, asked for benchmark results by name, made sure his extracurriculars were protected, and added targeted support at home based on what the evaluation had found. The year was different because we made it different, alongside the school, not waiting for the school.

THE SCIENCE

Different instruction:

The Florida and Indiana studies produced lasting gains because the instruction was different, not just the year. Intensive reading intervention, specifically structured literacy approaches like systematic phonics and explicit decoding instruction, was required alongside the repeated grade. Children received more minutes of targeted reading support per day than their advancing peers.

A note on who carries this:

In most families, one parent is running point on the school relationship — attending the meetings, reading the communications, managing the homework, tracking the progress, doing most of the daily work of holding this situation together. If that parent is you, this chapter is written for you.

Research on parental involvement is consistent: engaged parents produce better outcomes. That includes the parent who is already doing most of the work and the parent who is less involved and could change that.

The 10 minute rule:

Research on father involvement specifically finds that fathers who engage with their children in educational activity for approximately ten minutes per day produce measurable gains in primary school performance. This is not tutoring. It is engagement. Reading the same book together. Asking what happened in school. Helping with one homework problem.

Ten minutes. Daily. It is a small and specific change with documented impact.

Extracurricular identity:

When a child stays back, how he sees himself as a learner takes a significant hit. The antidote is not academic reassurance. It is non-academic success.

Sports teams, music classes, martial arts, swimming, scouting, art. Anything your child does alongside other children in which he can feel competent and included. These are not optional extras during the repeated year. A child who is the pitcher on a baseball team has an identity not defined by his grade. Protect it fiercely.

Sleep:

Sleep deprivation is one of the most common and most reversible causes of apparent academic and behavioral delay. A child getting seven hours of sleep instead of nine looks, in a classroom, like a child with attention problems or emotional dysregulation. He struggles to sit still, has trouble retrieving information he actually knows, and is irritable in ways that get interpreted as immaturity. It is a tired child.

Children aged five through nine need nine to eleven hours of sleep per night. Screens after dinner, irregular bedtimes, and overscheduled evenings are the most common causes, and they are fixable. If your child's sleep is short or irregular, address it for six to eight weeks before drawing any conclusions about his academic performance.

During the repeated year, protect bedtime the same way you protect the extracurricular activity.

Nutrition and movement:

Children who eat breakfast perform better on morning assessments. Children who exercise regularly show improved reading scores and attention compared to sedentary peers. During a year when your child is carrying more than usual, the basics matter more, not less.

What progress looks like at home:

Benchmarks with the teacher tell you how he is performing on assessments. But the parent at home has access to signals the teacher does not see, and they are often earlier and more honest.

In the first six weeks, watch for whether he is settling, not whether he is achieving. Does he walk in on Monday morning with less resistance. Does he mention a child in his new class by name. Settling is the precondition for learning. If it is happening, the year has a chance.

By October, look for small directional gains. For a reading gap: does he attempt words he would have skipped before. Directional is enough at two months.

By January, you should see something you can name. A book he finished. A friendship he maintained. A test he felt okay about. If you cannot name a single specific improvement, that is the conversation to have with his teacher. The year is half over and the plan either needs to be working or it needs to change.

One question to ask him regularly: what was something that felt easier this week than it used to. Not "how is school going." The specific question produces information.

Watch for these mental health signals:

School anxiety in this context looks specific: Sunday night stomachaches or headaches that disappear by Monday afternoon, complaints about school that are vague and persistent, morning resistance that escalates over weeks rather than fading.

These responses become a problem when they persist beyond the first few weeks, intensify rather than ease, or start affecting appetite, sleep, or mood outside of school hours. If you see this pattern developing, bring it to your pediatrician early. Early intervention for school anxiety is straightforward. Late intervention is harder.

The social bridge:

Peer relationships in early elementary are more resilient than parents expect. Children make new friends within a few weeks of a class change. In the weeks before school starts, arrange contact with close friends who are advancing. Let your child be the one to tell those friends what is happening rather than discovering it on the first day.

THE LESSON

Agreeing to the extra year is not the work. The work is what you do during it.

Stay involved. Check the benchmarks. Protect the extracurriculars. Show up for ten minutes a day. Give your child something to succeed at that has nothing to do with the grade on his classroom door.

TRY THIS

1. Request a meeting six weeks into the school year. To check whether the plan is being executed as described. Ask for the specific benchmark data. Compare it to what was promised.
2. Add summer preparation before the extra year begins. Six weeks of targeted work on the exact skills that are behind consistently changes outcomes. Not general enrichment. Targeted work.
3. Protect one extracurricular activity as non-negotiable. One thing he is good at, that he does with other children, unchanged during the repeated year. That activity is doing important work.
4. Do the ten minutes. Every day. Read with him. Ask about his day. Help with one problem. Put down the phone.
5. Set up one playdate with his closest friend before school starts. One afternoon, nothing academic. Let the friendship be normal before the school year makes it complicated.

Chapter 8: What to Say to Your Child

FIRST SON & SECOND SON

I handled the conversation with First Son badly.

He was five, nearly six. He did not fully understand what repeating kindergarten meant. But he understood enough to know that the kids he had spent the year with were moving on and he was not.

I told him in one brief conversation at the end of the year. He asked if his friend Tyler was staying too. I said no. He got quiet. I said it would be okay. He went to his room.

I accepted his "I'm fine" before school started because I needed it to be true. The first week was harder than either of us expected. We had talked about it in the abstract. The concrete version landed differently.

With Second Son, I spread it across several conversations. I let him be upset without rushing past it. We made a specific plan for the first week. When school started it was still not easy. But he was prepared for the hard part.

THE SCIENCE

Anderson and colleagues in 2005 found that children rate being held back as more stressful than losing a parent. What it means practically is that how you handle this conversation shapes his internal story about what this experience means. That story is what he carries into the repeated year.

Children do not need to be protected from difficult information. They need help building a narrative around it that is honest and leaves room for things to be okay.

For children in kindergarten and early first grade, grade structure is largely abstract. The fear is almost always social. Name the teacher for next year early. Arrange contact with close friends who are advancing. Give the child something concrete to hold onto.

For children in late first and second grade, the conversation needs to be honest about what is happening and why, and it needs to directly address the friendship question.

For children in second and third grade — the hardest age for this — ask him what he thinks happened this year before you explain what will happen next year. They may feel shame. They may feel angry. Both are valid and neither should be rushed past.

For children in third and fourth grade, the conversation becomes collaborative. What does he think would help. What does he want to be different next year. These questions produce more useful information than any amount of explanation.

What not to say at any age:

Do not use the word failed.

Do not say it is not a big deal.

Do not rush past his feelings to reassurance. Reassurance before acknowledgment sounds like dismissal.

Do not explain the decision in terms of what he could not do. Explain it in terms of what next year will make possible.

What to say when he asks if he is stupid:

The answer is not "of course not, you are so smart." That sounds like deflection.

The honest answer: reading is harder for your brain right now than it is for some other kids. That is true for a lot of kids and it has nothing to do with how smart you are. What we are doing next year is making sure reading gets easier, so that your smart brain has the right tools.

Short, specific, honest. Most children are relieved by it.

The friend conversation:

Your child should be the one to tell his close friends. Give him some control over how the story gets told. A short, matter of fact version: I am going to be in the same grade next year, my teachers thought I needed more time on some stuff, I am okay with it.

Children follow the emotional lead of the child delivering the news. If he is calm, his friends will be too.

THE LESSON

Feelings first. Facts second. Then the plan.

He does not need to be fine with this. He needs to know that you are not going to rush him past the hard feelings, and that there is a real plan on the other side of them.

TRY THIS

1. Have the first conversation before the end of the school year. He needs time to process. The summer is the processing time. Starting early gives it room.
2. Have several conversations, not one. The first plants the seed. The second addresses what came up. The third makes a specific plan for the first week of school.
3. Let him tell you what the hardest part is before you explain anything. Ask: what feels like the worst thing about this. His answer tells you exactly where to focus.
4. Make a specific plan for the first day. Who he will sit with. What he will do at recess. When he will see the friend who advanced. Concrete details make the abstract less frightening.
5. Let him tell his close friends himself. Before school starts. That story belongs to him, not to the school or to you.

What Comes Next

You have read the research. You have the questions. You know your rights and you know what the alternatives are. Whatever you decided, you made it with more information than most parents have when they sit in that room.

There is no perfect answer to this. The research is useful. It rules some things out. It makes the conditions for success clear. But it does not tell you exactly what to do in your particular situation with your particular child. Nobody can.

What I can tell you is this. The parents who get the best outcomes are not the ones who made the objectively correct grade placement decision. They are the ones who stayed engaged. Who asked the hard questions. Who showed up at the six-week meeting. Who protected the extracurricular and did the ten minutes. Who had the real conversation with their child instead of the one that felt easier.

That is you. The fact that you read this is evidence of it.

The extra year, if that is where you land, is not the whole story. It is the beginning of one. What you do during it is what the story becomes.

Go make it a genuinely different year.

- Jack

Appendix A: The Plan Checklist

- Bring this to the meeting. Ask for specific answers to every item.

Academic instruction:

- What specific skills or standards did my child not master this year
- What will be different about the instruction next year
- Will he have a different teacher
- What specific intervention program will be used
- How many minutes per day of targeted intervention
- What are the monthly benchmarks
- What is the escalation plan if benchmarks are not met

Evaluation:

- Has my child been evaluated for a learning disability or processing disorder
- When will that evaluation begin if it has not started
- Is an IEP or 504 plan being developed in parallel
- Has vision and hearing been evaluated by specialists recently

Social and physical support:

- What is the plan for the social transition during the first week
- What role will the school counselor play
- If physical development was a concern, what specialist evaluation is planned

Communication:

- How often will we receive progress updates
- Who is our primary contact
- What is the process if we feel the plan is not being followed

Appendix B: Signs to Watch For at Home

- A child who is not developmentally ready for the next grade typically shows difficulty across more than one of these areas, and the difficulty appears in multiple settings, not just at school.

Social readiness:

Cannot share or take turns without significant adult intervention.

Has meltdowns over minor routine changes that same-age peers handle without incident.

Struggles to read basic social cues in group settings.

Consistently seems like the youngest or least mature person in a group of same-age children.

Emotional readiness:

Cannot manage age-appropriate frustration.

Requires adult arbitration for minor peer conflicts.

Has significant anxiety about transitions or new situations that is out of proportion to his peers.

Language readiness:

Limited vocabulary compared to same-age peers at playdates or family gatherings.

Struggles to follow two or three step instructions at home.

Cannot retell what happened in a story told aloud.

Academic readiness:

Kindergarten: cannot identify most letters by January. Does not recognize that words are made of sounds.

First grade: not beginning to decode simple words by December.

Second grade: cannot read a simple paragraph independently by February.

Third grade: reading is clearly effortful and slow. Reading is avoided whenever possible.

Physical readiness:

Fine motor skills noticeably behind peers: handwriting, drawing, using scissors.

Gross motor coordination significantly behind peers.

Physical stamina for a full school day appears genuinely insufficient.

- If these signs appear mainly at school and not at home, the location of the problem may be the school environment, not the child's development.

Appendix C: How to Request a Formal Evaluation

- Send this in writing. Keep a copy with the date.

Dear [Principal or Special Education Coordinator name],

I am writing to formally request a comprehensive psychoeducational evaluation for my child, [child's full name], currently enrolled in [grade] at [school name].

I am requesting this evaluation under the Individuals with Disabilities Education Act. I am concerned that my child may have a learning disability, processing disorder, or other condition that is affecting his academic performance and may require specially designed instruction.

Please respond in writing with the timeline for completing this evaluation and the names of the assessors who will be involved.

Thank you.

[Your name]

[Date]

[Contact information]

Appendix D: Alternatives Reference

High dosage tutoring: Three or more sessions per week. Individual or very small group. Trained specialist using a structured program. Ask for the program name. Evidence base: Nickow, Oreopoulos, and Quan 2020 NBER review.

Summer retesting: Ask whether your district allows retesting at end of summer. Find out the assessment used and the passing threshold. Targeted summer tutoring before the retest has changed outcomes for many families.

Reading Recovery: One on one literacy intervention for first graders. Approximately twenty weeks with a trained Reading Recovery teacher. Strong evidence rating from the What Works Clearinghouse. Ask whether your school offers it or can refer to a provider.

IEP: Individualized Education Program. Provides specially designed instruction for children with identified learning disabilities. Requires formal evaluation. Request the evaluation in writing.

504 Plan: Provides classroom accommodations without the full specially designed instruction of an IEP. Useful for children whose disability can be managed with adjustments to how they are assessed and taught rather than changes to the curriculum itself.

Occupational therapy: For fine motor development concerns, sensory processing issues, or gross motor delays that are affecting school performance. Can be provided through the school or through a private provider.

Extended learning programs: Summer school or before and after school programs with targeted academic instruction. Ask specifically what program is used and what outcomes are tracked.

Appendix E: Five Questions to Ask Before You Agree

- Share this with another parent who needs it.

A school just recommended holding your child back. Before you say yes, ask these five questions. Write down the answers. The answers will tell you what you need to know.

1. What specifically did my child not master this year?

Not "he is not at grade level." A written list of the actual skills or standards. If the school cannot give you a specific list, the recommendation is not ready yet.

2. What will be different about the instruction next year?

Not more time. Not a fresh start. What will actually change. A different teacher. A specific intervention program with a name. More minutes of targeted support per day. If nothing changes, nothing will change.

3. Has my child been evaluated for a learning disability, vision problems, or hearing issues?

58 percent of children with learning disabilities are held back before anyone identifies the disability. Evaluation comes before grade placement, not after.

4. What are the monthly benchmarks, and what happens if he is not hitting them?

A real plan has checkpoints. If the school cannot describe what success looks like in October and January, there is no real plan yet.

5. What alternatives have been considered?

High dosage tutoring. Summer retesting. An IEP or 504 plan. Reading Recovery for first graders. Ask which of these were considered and why they were ruled out. The extra year is one option on a list. Know the full list before you choose.

- If the school can answer all five clearly and in writing, the conversation is worth continuing.

- If they cannot, you know what to ask for next.

- The Extra Year | FamilyForce | Jack Hartley